

as a kid. To him, reciting them wasn't challenging because they never changed. But congressmen did, which gave him new grist. The only time this ever really backfired on him was when Warren Buffett first started interacting with him. Because he had Buffett's father's name stuck in his head from Howard Buffett's days as Omaha's congressman, Father kept referring to Warren Buffett as "Howard," which came to periodically embarrass him when he caught it. Warren never called it to his attention. I pointed it out to Father several times, and he told me to mind my own business. But he loved watching election returns because it was the beginning of the next memorization cycle. It also linked to his interest in analyzing politics, something that always fascinated him. And he wasn't bad at it. He started with an advantage. Because he had all these guys names already memorized so well, he was a leg up on most folks. I'll bet at any one time there aren't 500 people in all of the United States who know all the names of all members of the House and the Senate. But he did. Always.

Also, because he knew the names, it was easier for him than for most folk, as elections approached, to learn and to memorize which were the races that were close and could go either way. Long before folks like political analyst Charles Cook refined his analytical structure, Father had the races categorized into groups by region as to safe seats for either party, semi-safe seats, and seats that were competitive to toss-ups. On election night, he would hone in on those relatively few seats that were the closest races and likely to go either way. As returns came in, he loved staying up late at night collecting data and writing them down and re-calibrating what that meant to the balance of power in Congress in the next two years and how that might effect the president and U.S. politics in general. He was not very good at knowing what would cause those close races to likely go one way or the other, nor did he think he was; but he knew which ones were close and watched them like a hawk. Just because I knew he wasn't good at knowing what would cause them to break one way or the other, I later put effort into getting specifically- trained to do just that—because I wanted to learn something I knew he didn't know how to do. Late in his life, he marveled that I could do it because it was inconceivable to him that anyone could. But it is a pretty simple set of skills. The irony is that if earlier in his career someone had taught him how to do it, he could readily have done it quite well and, I'm sure, far better than I could. But another feature of his life was that any technique he didn't learn before age fifty, he probably never